

Personal Cyber Safety Guide for Australian Technology Users

A Comprehensive Guide to Protecting Yourself in the Digital Age



Scams work because they exploit common human instincts: trust, urgency, and greed. This guide won't just list warning signs; it will explain the psychology behind them, so you can recognise an attack even when it takes a form you haven't seen before.

Note

This guide draws on threat intelligence from the Australian Cyber Security Centre (ACSC) and Scamwatch.

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Email is the most common entry point for scams in Australia, accounting for 73% of reported incidents in 2023 (ACSC). Understanding why phishing works is more useful than memorising a checklist.

The mechanics of a phishing email

Scammers don't need to break into your accounts; they need you to hand over access voluntarily. A convincing phishing email does three things:

1. **Impersonates a trusted sender.** The display name might read "myGov Alerts," but the actual sending address is something like `service@mygov-updates.net`. Legitimate Australian government communications always come from `.gov.au` domains. Hover over (or tap and hold on mobile) any sender name before acting.
2. **Creates artificial urgency.** Phrases like "immediate action required" or "your account will be suspended" are designed to short-circuit careful thinking. The ATO and other government agencies do not threaten immediate arrest or account closure by email.
3. **Disguises malicious links.** A button labelled "Verify Now" might lead to `mygov-signin.secureportal.live`, not myGov. Always hover over links to inspect the real destination, and when in doubt, navigate directly by typing the address yourself (e.g., `my.gov.au`).

Psychological triggers to watch for

Scammers consistently exploit the same handful of instincts:

- **Authority:** Impersonating banks, the ATO, myGov, or tech companies like Microsoft.
- **Urgency:** Demanding action within hours to prevent a consequence.
- **Curiosity or greed:** Offers that seem improbably good.
- **Social proof:** Claims that "thousands of Australians have already claimed" a benefit.

When you feel any of these pressures from an unsolicited contact, treat it as a signal to slow down, not speed up.

Romance Scams: When the Threat Is Emotional

Romance scams cost Australians over \$40 million annually (ACSC 2023). They succeed not because victims are naive, but because the scammer invests weeks or months building a relationship before asking for anything.

How it unfolds

The approach is consistent regardless of the platform (dating apps, Facebook, even email):

1. **Establishing contact:** The scammer presents an attractive profile, often using photos stolen from social media influencers or real military personnel. They make contact and move quickly toward intimacy.
2. **Building the relationship:** Excuses for never appearing on video (“my camera is broken,” “I’m on a remote mine site with no internet”) are standard. Every detail of your life shared on social media becomes material for building false familiarity.
3. **The financial request:** After weeks or months, a crisis emerges: a medical emergency, a stranded visa, a cancelled mining contract. Money is requested via untraceable channels: gift cards (iTunes, Steam), Western Union, or cryptocurrency.

Red flags at a glance

Sign	What it looks like
Rapid emotional escalation	“I love you” within days or weeks
Avoids real-time verification	Endless excuses for no video calls or visits
Financial sob stories	“My contract fell through, I just need help with rent”
Untraceable payment requests	Gift cards, wire transfers, or cryptocurrency

The manipulation toolkit

Three tactics appear in almost every romance scam:

- *Love bombing:* Overwhelming flattery and attention early, designed to create emotional dependency before you’ve had time to think critically.
- *Gaslighting:* Making you doubt your own suspicions (“I can’t believe you’d think that after everything I’ve shared with you”).
- *Guilt-tripping:* “If you really cared about me, you’d help.”

How to protect yourself

Verify the person, not just the story. Run profile photos through Google Lens or TinEye; scammers routinely recycle stolen images. Insist on a live, unscripted video call. A genuine person will understand; a scammer will produce an excuse. Cross-check claimed employers and locations against publicly available information, using contact details you find independently, not those they provide.

Treat financial requests as disqualifying. Legitimate partners do not ask for money before meeting in person, regardless of the circumstances they describe. The ACSC has documented cases where victims mortgaged their homes to send cryptocurrency to fake trading accounts. If you find yourself considering sending money to someone you’ve never met, stop and call someone you trust first.

Slow the relationship down deliberately. Share what you’re experiencing with a trusted friend or family member. Outsiders spot red flags that emotional involvement makes easy to miss.

If you’re already in contact

1. Cease all communication.
2. Report the profile to the platform (dating app or social media).
3. Preserve all messages and transaction records as evidence.

4. Report to Scamwatch and, if money was sent, to your bank and local police immediately.

Warning

The scammer is not in love with you. The entire relationship is constructed to reach the moment of financial transfer. No genuine romantic connection begins with a request for money.

Advance-Fee and Inheritance Scams (The “419”)

Named after Nigeria’s Section 419 fraud laws, these scams have modernised considerably but follow the same core logic: the victim pays upfront fees for a large promised reward that never arrives.

Current variants targeting Australians

- *Mining investment scams:* A fraudster posing as a mining executive seeks a local partner to “process gold ore” or “secure mining rights.” Fake documents carry Australian government logos and reference real locations like the Pilbara to appear credible.
- *Inheritance scams:* An email from a “law firm” (complete with a fake ABN) describes an unclaimed estate, often using a surname that matches yours or is common enough to seem plausible.

Why they work

The scam is engineered to feel legitimate through careful staging:

- Fake government letterheads and legal terminology establish authority.
- Lists of supposed previous beneficiaries provide false social proof.
- The initial ask is small; larger sums are requested only after the victim has already committed money and feels unable to walk away.

The defining characteristic is fees paid in advance for rewards that remain perpetually just out of reach. Each new payment is justified by a fresh complication. There is no estate, no gold, no reward.

Safe Software Practices

A significant proportion of malware infections begin with a software download that seemed routine. The source matters as much as the software itself.

Where to get software

Platform	Trusted sources	Warning signs
Android	Google Play Store	APK files from emails or websites
iOS	Apple App Store	Prompts to trust an enterprise profile
Windows / macOS	Microsoft Store or vendor's own site	"Cracked" or "free" versions of paid apps

Before installing anything

- Confirm the developer name matches the official company exactly.
- For sensitive software, verify the file checksum against the value published on the vendor's own site.
- Review requested permissions. A calculator has no legitimate need for access to your contacts or microphone; revoke anything that doesn't make sense for the app's purpose.

Bitcoin and Cryptocurrency Security

The greatest risks to Australian cryptocurrency holders are no longer exchange collapses; they are targeted social engineering and malware campaigns.

Clipboard hijackers

Sophisticated malware can silently replace a cryptocurrency wallet address you've copied with an attacker's address at the moment you paste it. Victims paste what looks correct and only discover the substitution after the transaction is confirmed and irreversible. Always verify the full destination address character by character before confirming any transfer, regardless of how the address was obtained.

SIM-swapping

Attackers social-engineer telco support staff into porting your phone number to a SIM they control. With your number, they can bypass SMS-based two-factor authentication on exchange accounts and drain funds within minutes. The ACCC found that 78% of crypto-related fraud cases in 2024 involved a compromised phone number.

Defences:

- Contact your mobile provider (Telstra, Optus, Vodafone) and request a number porting lock. It's free.
- Replace SMS-based 2FA with an authenticator app (e.g., Authy) or a hardware security key for any account with financial access.
- Use a hardware wallet for any significant holdings. Treat the device you sign transactions on as hostile: dedicate a separate machine for that purpose, and never install wallet software found via a search engine.

If you suspect compromise

Contact your telco immediately through verified channels, freeze connected financial accounts, and transfer remaining funds to a freshly generated wallet. Report to the ACSC's ReportCyber portal and contact IDCARE (1800 595 160) for identity recovery support.

Password Security: Length Beats Complexity

The famous [xkcd comic #936](https://xkcd.com/936/)¹ made a point that security professionals have since confirmed: length is more important than complexity. A password like Tr0ub4dor&3 is hard to remember and easier to crack than it looks. A four-word passphrase like kangaroo sunshine pavlova footy is both memorable and, at 25+ characters, vastly more resistant to brute-force attack.

Building a passphrase

Choose four to six unrelated, concrete words (avoid famous phrases or song lyrics):

- window avocado lightning tractor
- guitar waterfall koala telescope

If a site requires numbers or symbols, append them rather than scattering them through the passphrase:

- window avocado lightning tractor 42
- window!avocado?lightning\$tractor

Managing passphrases

You should have a unique passphrase for every account; reusing credentials means one breach exposes everything. A password manager like Bitwarden handles this: it generates and stores unique passphrases, fills them in automatically (which also defeats keyloggers), and requires only one master passphrase to unlock.

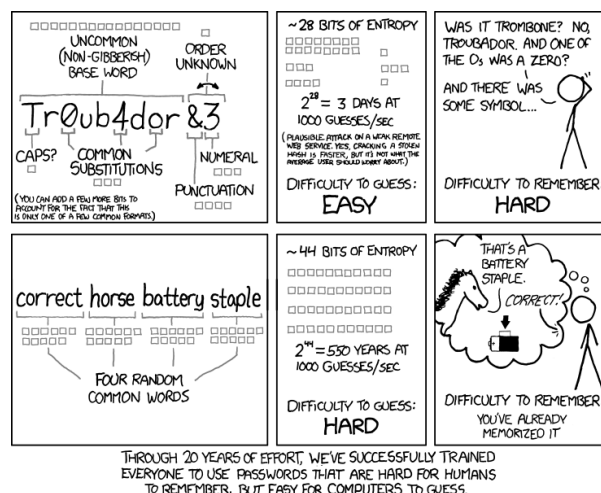


Fig. 1: Visual explanation of password strength (Credit: xkcd)

¹ <https://xkcd.com/936/>

The Mistake That Runs Through Every Scam

Every scam in this guide shares a common mechanism: the victim trusted who they were communicating with without verifying it first.

The phishing victim trusted the email address looked right. The romance scam victim trusted the relationship felt real. The 419 victim trusted the documents looked official.

This is worth sitting with, because the same failure mode applies to this very document.

If you contacted us intending to report a scam to the Australian Cyber Security Centre, you've come to the wrong place. We are **Cyber IT Solutions** (cyber.com.au), a private cybersecurity consultancy. The government's reporting site is cyber.gov.au, operated by the ACSC. One word's difference in the domain: .com.au versus .gov.au.

That's the same mechanism your scammer used. A domain, a name, or a number close enough to pass a quick glance. The habit of pausing to verify before handing over information is exactly what this guide has been building toward, and it applies here just as much as it does to a PayPal email or a romantic stranger online. It's a learnable habit, not an innate talent, and you now have the tools.

Verification steps to apply every time before sharing information or sending money

For organisations and businesses:

- Hover over links before clicking to see the actual destination URL.
- Look up phone numbers on the organisation's official website and call that number yourself, rather than calling back a number provided by the contact.
- Check email sender addresses character by character. service@paypal-support.net is not PayPal.

For individuals:

- Run profile photos through Google Lens or TinEye to check for stolen images.
- Insist on a live, real-time video call with no filters.
- If someone claims to be a family member in trouble, hang up and call them on their known number before doing anything else.

For all contacts, solicited or not:

- Slow down. Any legitimate contact will accept a short delay while you verify; anyone who won't is almost certainly a scammer (or aggressively rude).
- Search the organisation's name alongside the word "scam" to see whether others have reported it.

The rule that covers everything

If I didn't initiate this contact, I won't trust until I've verified through an independent channel.

Where to Report and Get Help

If you've been targeted or have lost money, act quickly. Banks can sometimes reverse or freeze transactions if contacted promptly.

Immediate steps

1. *Financial loss:* Contact your bank's fraud line immediately. For cryptocurrency, notify the receiving exchange.
2. *Account compromise:* Change passwords, enable 2FA, and check email settings for unauthorised forwarding rules.
3. *Malware infection:* Disconnect from all networks and seek professional advice; a clean reinstall of your operating system is often the safest path.

Reporting channels

- Scamwatch [Romance Scams](https://www.scamwatch.gov.au/types-of-scams/dating-romance)²
- Scamwatch [General Scams](https://www.scamwatch.gov.au/)³
- [IDCARE](https://www.idcare.org)⁴ for identity theft and recovery support (1800 595 160)
- [ReportCyber](https://www.cyber.gov.au/report/)⁵ for serious cybercrime incidents (ACSC) — note: this is `cyber.gov.au`, not `cyber.com.au`
- Local police, if money has been transferred

Building the habit going forward

The goal is not to become paranoid; it's to add one deliberate pause before acting on any unsolicited contact. Subscribe to ACSC alerts to stay across emerging threats, and share what you've learned: scammers rely on victims not talking to anyone about what happened.

² <https://www.scamwatch.gov.au/types-of-scams/dating-romance>

³ <https://www.scamwatch.gov.au/>

⁴ <https://www.idcare.org>

⁵ <https://www.cyber.gov.au/report/>

Need Professional Cybersecurity Assistance?

If your organisation needs professional support with cybersecurity risk, incident response, or security architecture, we'd be glad to help.

Cyber IT Solutions Pty Ltd
www.cyber.com.au⁶

⁶ <https://www.cyber.com.au/>